

Loewy “believed that consumers are torn between two opposing forces: *neophilia*, a curiosity about new things; and *neophobia*, a fear of anything too new. As a result, they gravitate to products that are bold, but instantly comprehensible.” Any innovation too far ahead of the curve gets rejected by much of the public.

But with music, I suspect MAYA varies with age. The receptiveness to new music is different for a critic in their 30s, 40s or 50s than for teenagers. One group is still in its formative age, embracing new things (and rejecting most of what their parents liked); the others’ formative years were decades earlier. Once your musical taste hardens, perhaps you are less receptive to the latest sounds.

This might explain the bad reviews from Beatles critics throughout their career. Many of their albums, including some of the best music ever recorded, were initially panned. Musicologist and historian Ted Gioia observed that critics “literally were handed the greatest recordings of their era to review, and blew them off. Every classic song on these albums was not only attacked, but actually mocked.”²⁶

MAYA helps explain why.

Gioia notes that The Beatles were “punished for how quickly they were pushing rock music ahead... the critics misunderstood the lads from Liverpool for the worst possible reason—namely, that they were constantly learning, growing more ambitious, and absolutely willing to take risks.”

Or as UK rocker Elvis Costello said, “Every [Beatles] record was a shock.”²⁷

The Ed Sullivan appearance was merely a single episode in an explosive career. Throughout the 1960s, bad reviews of Beatles albums such as *Sgt. Pepper’s*, *the White Album*, and *Abbey Road* would come back to haunt the critics who penned them.



“Nobody knows anything” surely applies to music, but let’s return to